



Foreign Business Trips

"I dislike feeling at home when I am abroad."

—George Bernard Shaw

You are a young professional and you are sent on a foreign business trip by your organization—that is what dreams are made of. In spite of globalization, foreign trips are still glamorous. With the 'official' tag attached to it, it broadcasts to the whole world that you are now an important member of your organization and that they entrust you with their crucial assignments. With this importance comes certain euphoria—a feeling of elevation to the stratosphere and that you are in a different league now.

What we stress in this chapter are some basic etiquette that you need to follow before, during and after your foreign visit and not let the euphoria obscure what you have to do.

With foreign trips becoming an increasingly common part of regular work requirement and with such trips becoming very crucial to the success of the organization and your personal success, these tips on etiquette can help you to get higher mileage for your trip (no pun intended).

33.1 GENERAL GUIDELINES ABOUT FOREIGN BUSINESS TRIPS

Before we go into the specifics of what you should do before, during and after the trip, here are a few general guidelines.

When you are on a company business trip, your individual identity is overridden by your organization's identity and you will have to represent it throughout the trip. Not just this, but you will also be representing the face of modern Indian professionalism to the rest of the world. This means that you will have to exercise tremendous restraint and good judgement in case of any ordeals during your trip. You are not an anonymous tourist going on a pleasure trip. Some of the things to remember about this are:

- ▶ As an ambassador of your organization, ensure you don't let your organization down. Don't criticize or deride it under any circumstance, and especially in mixed company. Whatever grouses you may have within your organization, they shouldn't raise their ugly heads during a business trip.
- ▶ During the trip, if you have to make any business commitment to other parties on behalf of your organization, remember to make only those commitments that are within your level of authority.
- ▶ You are also representing your country—India. In your awe of seeing American expressways, do not bad mouth Indian roads and traffic to your American counterparts.
- ▶ Do not hesitate to keep up your religious and personal identity (e.g., religious symbols on your body) but don't let that divert the purpose of your visit—namely to transact business for your organization.
- ▶ If you have food habits that require special needs (e.g., vegetarianism), make sure you use the Internet and other resources to find out appropriate places nearby.
- ▶ Remember in the USA, travelling by car is the default option. When you ask someone for directions to a place, they will probably say 'take 101 North, turn right on Hillsdale East and take the third left and you are there . . .'. No one will tell you which bus takes you to the place. If you are not driving, you would have to put some serious thought on how to get to your destination. Cabs are prohibitively expensive. You may have to ask someone for a *ride* (not *lift*, as you say in India). Or you may have to do extensive research on the modes of public transport in your destination and figure out the details.

33.2 BEFORE YOU LEAVE ON YOUR TRIP

Like any form of activity, knowing your objectives and planning ahead is very essential.

33.2.1 Know Your Objectives

First and foremost, *know your mission*. Understand clearly why you are going on this trip. Learn also about the strategic plan behind the trip. If your trip is a part of

a bigger plan, find out where your trip fits in the grand scheme. There should be a sense of purpose, an excitement in the air, about doing an important job for your organization and a 'now or never' kind of urgency to get the mission accomplished—like a batsman getting on to the crease.

Some possible missions that could be the cause for your trip are:

- ▶ A technical mission like installing a software product on your customer site.
- ▶ A knowledge transfer by which you are going to get trained by your foreign counterparts.
- ▶ A 'scoping out' trip to do due diligence.
- ▶ The final step in winning an off-shoring deal.

Other questions related to your trip could be:

- ▶ Who are accompanying you and how are you dividing your responsibilities with those travelling with you?
- ▶ Are there specific numerical targets or specific expectations? Is there a prized trophy you need to bring home on your return?

These may be the stated objectives of the trip that you have to achieve no matter what. But oftentimes, there are unstated objectives, which are even more important, that would have to be met. One such would be *rapport building*. It is likely that you and the people whom you meet in your trip are going to be interacting with each other frequently in future. This trip may well be the beginning of a new relationship. In that case, building a good rapport during the trip is of paramount importance. As we have seen several times in this book, there is nothing like a face-to-face meeting to get us to the same page. When you go on a trip, you have the time and opportunity to get to know your counterparts, and build (or cement) enduring relationships. You can use the entire arsenal that we have discussed in the book—small talk, body language, appropriate language, bridging cultural divides and the whole works. This rapport would take you and your organization to greater distances than just the tactical goals of your trip.

A second unstated objective of your trip would be *building networks*. In addition to meeting the people with whom you directly transact the stated business purpose, you would also be expected to build a network of contacts that would come in handy sooner or later. The network could be for potential future deals or just for getting help in certain areas where you know you or your organization need help.

33.2.2 Prepare Well

Remember that a lot may be riding on your trip. So, you have to prepare for it meticulously.

- ▶ Make sure you have assembled and organized all data required for your trip both in the hard copy and in the soft copy, as necessary. If hard copies are required,

you are much better off taking them from your home turf rather than going hunting for printers and fax machines in a new place.

- ▶ Make sure you have written down the contact numbers of essential people and places in your organizer/cell phone as well as in your old-fashioned diary. There is no point arriving in London and discovering that you forgot to get the latest numbers or that all the numbers are on your cell phone and you are unable to charge your cell phone.
- ▶ Build redundancy and save your important material in two or three places. Make contingency plans for such possibilities as lost luggage and have someone in your home base who can feed you computer files, data and other things in a pinch.
- ▶ Make sure your desktop in your home base office is clean and properly organized. If you have to ask someone to send you things from your home base office, make sure the things are easily located on your desk—don't send him on a wild goose chase.
- ▶ Make sure you have all your travel documents in order. Also, look at the security notices and warnings that airlines and governments issue every now and then that places seemingly impossible restrictions on hand baggage.
- ▶ Make sure you carry power adapters for the several different power outlets of the parts of the world you are visiting. It is a good idea to have a universal adapter.
- ▶ If you are a part of a delegation, you will have to make sure that you have covered all the materials among all of you and that nothing has slipped through the cracks.
- ▶ Finally, make sure you bring with you plenty of your latest business cards and a diary or journal with a couple of good pens.

33.3 DURING YOUR TRIP

Be aware of the local laws and practices: Be very careful about the local laws and about inadvertently violating them. For example, in several countries there are stringent laws about jaywalking or littering. Follow them diligently. If you take prescription medications, make sure you pack enough for the days you are traveling—otherwise it is next to impossible to get a new prescription in a foreign country and get it filled at the foreign pharmacies. Also, before you leave for your trip, find out the weather at your destination and dress appropriately. (Your company may also have a dress code for foreign trips. Consult it.) Remember that winters in the USA or Europe are far more severe than anything you have experienced in India and so, your winter clothing should be appropriate. In fact, you may want to buy them after landing up in the foreign country. Also, be aware of luggage rules and limits—they can differ for different countries and air carriers.

Respect privacy: Privacy is such an important concept that we have dedicated an entire chapter for it (Chapter 36). When you are abroad, respect for the privacy of your foreign counterparts is extremely essential. Do not expect them to chaperon you during the off-hours or go out of their way to help you with your travel or personal needs. (But most of them will tell you how to get around or what to do and give helpful pointers.)

Interface with your foreign team: Nowadays, most organizations have at least a sales office or other facilities in several foreign countries. Interface well with your permanent team in the foreign location. Get to know them and liaison with them. They will have a wealth of information about the organization you are going to visit, how to do business in that country and a host of valuable tips in general. Integrate your efforts with their efforts and put on a unified front.

Pay attention to networking: Understand that one of the main components of your trip is to build relationship and trust. A face-to-face meeting can help in building a strong relationship with your contacts in your host company and therefore, a cooperative environment between your two organizations. Even if it is only a scouting trip or even if you lose the deal eventually, such relationships are extremely valuable and you must practice on getting perfect at it. Right at the outset, get to know the names of the persons you meet (and also the name they want to go by). Some people would prefer to be called Robert, some others Bob and yet others Rob. (They may get offended if you referred to Rob as Bob). Project an exuberant, extroverted and confident personality. Remember that every person you meet in a foreign organization can be valuable in some way or the other and so, spend a lot of time talking and liaison with your hosts.

Help conduct perfect presentations and meetings: Pull off a perfect meeting with the hosts. We have already mentioned several pointers to achieve this in our earlier chapters. The only extra thing we want to say here is that often, you may have to present your colleague's presentation materials as well (your company cannot afford to send everyone in your group on this trip), in which case, make sure that you understand this presentation inside and out and can answer a lot of questions from your hosts. Likewise, your colleagues might ask you to obtain specific information for them from your hosts. Make sure you collect it for them. Work as a team with your contingent and make sure you are always connected with them. Don't drift away on your own private mission. Also, time management is very critical when you are abroad—given that you will be in a different time zone, your body clock can get seriously affected by jetlag and it will not have the time to adjust to the local time.

Be in constant touch with your home base and your boss in India: Be constantly in touch with your boss in India. Schedule a regular time slot for daily phone updates. More detailed reports should be sent to him via e-mail everyday and even more

frequently, as necessary. Copy other relevant people. Before any major commitment or action, consult with the chief of your team and then clear it with your boss in India. Don't do anything major on your own—just because you think it is the right response—and hope that your boss will agree to it.

It is okay to talk in your native language amongst yourselves: If it helps you communicate better among yourselves—and also to have a semblance of privacy—you may want to switch from English to your native language in meetings in your host organization. However, desist from making any derogatory comments or nasty remarks about your hosts—in such an instance, often your body language will give it away and your hosts may figure it out. In fact, you have to be very careful about having private conversations with your team members or members from your permanent team in the host country. Just remember that even walls have ears and so, make triply sure that you are in a safe place to discuss such things.

A business trip is not a junket: Business trips cost a lot of money to your organization, on top of all kinds of man hours spent on getting your visas and other paperwork. So, it is important to treat it as a very serious business activity that should bring about favourable results in the end. Any personal sightseeing or visiting your relatives or shopping should be done only when there is free time available outside your meetings and office work. And don't be at all surprised if you are asked to go to London or New York City for just two days—and you actually spend the entire time holed up in an office building attending intense meetings and discussions.



"Excuse me, but which way is it to the Buckingham Palace?...."

Fig. 33.1

Usually, you can schedule evenings and weekends for personal activities. Even then, make sure your group members know where you will be and how to get in touch with you. Sometimes your organization may allow you to stay back in the foreign country on a personal vacation, if your office schedule permits it—in which case, save your sightseeing and other tourist activities for then.

Be frugal about spending money: Whether it is your money or the company's money, exercise restraint about spending it. Don't splurge. As such, it is an expensive proposition to send people abroad and so, do your part in being conscious about the costs. Find out your company's spending policy and adhere to it meticulously. If cities you visit have good public transportation

systems, make use of them where you can. At the same time, you don't have to endure extra-ordinary tribulations to save a buck and walk five kilometres. Save all your receipts and file timely expense reports. A lot of things that are free in India and taken for granted, are not necessarily free in other countries. So understand what you are in for before requesting a service. Be very careful in using hotel phones, Internet facility or laundry services—understand the charges before indulging. In a country like the USA, labour is very expensive and so any labour-intensive service can be expensive. Get to know the tipping practices in various countries and what services need to be tipped. In Singapore, a tip is included in a restaurant bill, whereas in the USA, a tip on the order of fifteen percent of the bill is extra and is expected, whether or not the service is satisfactory.

The guiding principle should be to do things in moderation and to be always cost-conscious. While you should enjoy the many aspects of a foreign trip, don't overdo it or be that big-spending foreign tourist.

33.4 AFTER THE TRIP

First, send a courteous 'Thank You' mail to your counterparts, thanking them for their hospitality and for the productive time you had. Then, sit down with your boss and brief him on the trip (if appropriate, you can do this in a group meeting with your entire team present). Write an appropriate trip report and circulate it among the relevant people. Next, follow through on the action items you promised and take them to completion. And of course, don't forget to file that expense report promptly with all your receipts, before you start your next trip on your globe trotting.

33.5 IN SUMMARY

Foreign visits are great opportunities to get exposure to excellent work ethics, diversity of cultures and it is an experience to see the different parts of our planet. In addition to achieving your business objectives—which are of course paramount—you should also try to get an appreciation of this diversity and ethics. That learning, together with the goal of building rapport and your network, would stand you in good stead as you move forward in your career.

Here is a quick summary of the points we discussed in this chapter.

- ▶ Make sure you understand the role you need to play in the trip.
- ▶ Plan well for your trip, get all data and documents organized before you leave.
- ▶ Carry everything you need for your work—business cards, relevant documents, etc.
- ▶ Have a backup in your office in India so that he can access your data, if needed.
- ▶ Respect the local laws and the privacy of your hosts.

- ▶ Build rapport and your networks in addition to accomplishing your specific tasks.
- ▶ Keep your home office informed.
- ▶ Be very cost conscious.
- ▶ Debrief the appropriate people after return and formally close out the issues with your foreign counterparts
- ▶ And don't forget to thank your foreign hosts for their hospitality.